

Woodwind

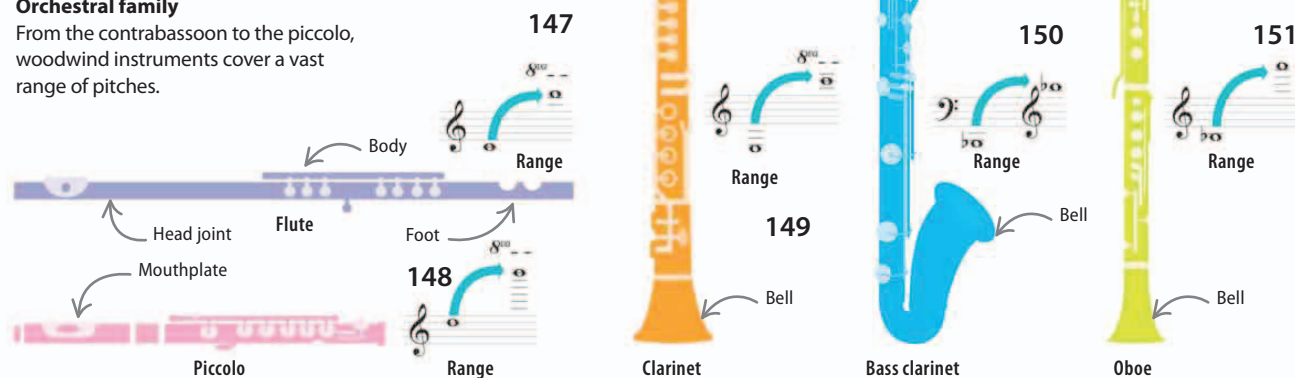
Woodwind instruments are wood or metal tubes with holes that, when covered by fingertips or finger-operated keys, create different pitches. The instruments range from simple whistles to those used in modern orchestras and bands.

Orchestral woodwinds

Pairs of flutes, oboes, clarinets, and bassoons form the heart of an orchestra. Smaller or larger versions feature occasionally—especially the piccolo, cor anglais, bass clarinet, and contrabassoon—extending the range of notes available in the woodwind section, and adding special colors, or timbres, to the texture.

Orchestral family

From the contrabassoon to the piccolo, woodwind instruments cover a vast range of pitches.



SEE ALSO

◀ 106–107 Musical markings

The orchestra 184–185 ▶

Ensembles 188–189 ▶

What is the score? 194–195 ▶

Saxophones

Invented around 1840 by Belgian Adolphe Sax, the saxophone is a "hybrid" instrument with a brass body, a single reed like the clarinet, and a conical tube like the oboe. Widely used in jazz and band music, saxophones are occasionally used in orchestras to play distinctively warm, lyrical solos.

Sounding pitches for saxophones

Saxophones are made in several different sizes, the most popular ones being soprano, alto, tenor, and baritone. Together, they cover a wide range of pitches.

